moral vacuum. In essence, the difference between a border and a frontier is that a border needs to be controlled by the state. Its law and order is determined by the state, and the sovereignty of the state in terms of the monopoly on the use of force is indisputable. By contrast, the political order of the frontier can be mutually constituted between the state and locals, and therefore is more flexible. This difference in terms of the level of state control has important bearing on the development of the political order in a border and a frontier.

In his study of post-colonial statecraft in the Philippines, Wong Pak Nun (2013) suggests that frontier strongmen should not be seen as a threat to the state, but could be co-opted in the state-building process to bridge the development and resistance dichotomy. Essentially, Wong argues that decentralization of state management to local strongmen could help to pacify the frontier. The tools that facilitate the decentralization are networking, identity switching, and brokering (Wong 2013, p. 94). In short, through a process of co-optation the frontier is treated as separate from the state but is made to work for the state by bringing local strongmen into a client-patron relationship.

To understand the Pa-O SAZ as a frontier requires identification of the key political actors in the area who need to be co-opted by the state, and consideration of how they are co-opted. Accordingly, this chapter is divided into several sections. The first section sketches the political, economic, and social landscape of the southern Shan State, drawing attention in particular to the rivalry between the two major ethnic groups in the area: the Shan and Pa-O. This leads to a descriptive section on the main political actors in the area, who are divided into three categories: actors from the Pa-O community; actors from the Shan community; and actors from the international community. The next section examines the co-optation mechanism, who gets co-opted and why, and what sort of political order is established as a result. The subsequent section examines the effectiveness of the political order in terms of augmenting state control in the area by using the 2015 election result as the reference point. Finally, the analysis concludes that ceasefire capitalism can help to transform warlords to state builders; however, show of force still determines the political order in a frontier.